Playing the Past, Predicting the Future: Sortes Texts in Virtual Reality

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Philology is fundamentally the science of texts, yet texts are inseparable from the documents that carry them. In a way, scholarly editions start from the most "internal" perspective, that of a text *in* a document, to then, in some cases, surpass the limitations of the latter in a reconstructive effort aimed at restoring an idea of lost textuality as synthesis of multiple extant documents. In our project we approach a historical text literally from the *outside* , that is, from the rooms in which the document was likely to be used, to then zoom in via the document to the text itself and its translation.

The texts we focus on belong to the genre of the *sortes*. The *sortes* are divinatory texts with roots in Late Antiquity (Heiles 2018 and Heiles et al. 2021). They were used throughout the Middle Ages for predicting the future and answering questions related to the everyday life and struggles of the people. These texts often required the user to anticipate the consultation of the text by performing specific rituals, such as cleansing, fasting, praying or wearing specific clothing. Furthermore, it was necessary to use randomising mechanisms to navigate non-sequential reading paths in the codex, in order to disclose the predictions. The paths usually stretched from a question chosen by the reader at the beginning of the text to an answer which was given at the very end, after the user had visited a multiplicity of interactive stations. Given the ludic nature of this genre, the *sortes* were reinterpreted as social games in the course of the Middle Ages. Faced with the challenge of editing one such work, the Prenostica Socratis Basilei (PSB) in its mediaeval German versions, we soon recognised the limitations of the editorial effort.

We do aim at publishing a scholarly edition in accordance with the computational paradigm (Cugliana 2023, Cugliana et al. 2024a and Cugliana et al. 2024b). The modelling of the text, which is the basis for the creation of a digital scholarly edition, establishes a theory and an interpretation of the text (McGann 2001). But this represents a too limited view on the documents being edited: complementary to the model of the *text* expressed in the computational scholarly edition, we model a hypothetical, yet evidence based, process of *using* the document. We complement the textual view of the document with a performative view, in which the text in the document is seen as a script for performing certain underspecified activities with non-deterministic outcomes. Thus, what we are presenting in this paper is an addition to the edition project, a new opening which we regard as a bridge between the fields of philology, media studies and media archaeology.[1]

The performative modelling led to the creation of a VR application[2] which we designed to simulate the contextualised historical use of a *sortes* text.[3] We chose a manuscript which is currently being edited in the aforementioned PSB project, as it was already available both as a transcription and in translation (Schneider 1976 and 1978). We situated the codex in three virtual contexts: a monastic library, an astrologer's laboratory, and a tavern. These symbolise the places where *sortes* texts, in general (as specific information on the contexts of use of specific witnesses are very rare), were likely to be used in the Middle Ages (Heiles 2018), thus simulating specific settings for the performances. The three selected contexts represent, respectively, the spiritual, scientific and playful interpretations of the *sortes* . In this way we seek to recreate the multisensory experiences and ritualistic interactions that characterised mediaeval engagement with this genre. Users interact with an immersive, animated 3D model of the

codex, employing dice and tools within these virtual spaces. The simulation system was developed in Unreal Engine 5.3 with Meta Quest 3 head mounted displays as the devices used in the development.

The modelling work we carried out in praxis led to a deeper understanding of our object of research and to the formulation of new research questions,[4] which we will address in our presentation. Our first research question challenges the role of digital presentation of multimodal historical objects carrying texts: how can we make texts and documents come to life for the modern audience? Clearly, we need to extend the attention beyond the merely textual dimension and start looking at these documents in their materiality, at what *surrounds* them and at how they afford certain performative acts. To put it simply, you need to be in the same room where the book is in order to read it. And of course, you could not read it without first opening it![5] But, and we come to our next research question: what aspects make materiality feel real? We claim that interaction is key. Real pages have their weight and you cannot feel it until you slip your fingers between them and turn them. A simulation is not a reconstruction of the real experience, but it offers the users additional aspects of the experience. In this sense, simulation is also storytelling, a reimagining, a way of engaging with the past that underscores the vitality of texts and documents and brings them closer to modern audiences.

To conclude, if the goal of scholarly editions is to save written culture and memory from their perpetual condemnation to oblivion (Petrucci 2004) then scholarly editing as a discipline should continually adapt and innovate its "mnemotechniques"[6] (Assmann 2007) to align with the evolving ways modern audiences receive and consume content.[7] In the digital environment, this evolution often occurs at the intersection of various media.[8] Furthermore, recognising the *intrinsic* multimodality of text – where communication extends beyond words to include visual, auditory and interactive elements – represents a pivotal shift in how we represent and engage with textuality.

Notes

1. For the recently established field of media archaeology cf., among others, Parikka (2012) and Marx (2024).
2. A walkthrough-video presenting the main features of the prototype is available at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yu2uHmaOksE (accessed November 27, 2024).
3. Thus, the general model of the performance was translated into a simulation of specific performances.
4. This is an important aspect of modelling in the (digital) humanities, as well as beyond, cf. Ciula et.al. (2023: 71).
5. A humorous comment is made in "Medieval helpdesk", produced by the Norwegian Broadcasting Corporation (NRK) from 2001, cf. https://tv.nrk.no/serie/oeystein-og-meg/sesong/4/episode/FUHA16000101 (accessed 25.11.2024); with English subtitles: https://youtu.be/pQHX-SjgQvQ (accessed 25.11.2024).
6. That is, the methods and practices through which knowledge and collective memory is preserved and transmitted.
7. An example of mnemotechnical adaptation is the instagram project "Ich bin Sophie Scholl", by the German Südwestrundfunk (SWR) and Bayerischer Rundfunk (BR), described in the blog article of the "Bildungsstätte Anne Frank": https://www.bs-anne-frank.de/mediathek/blog/zum-instagram-projekt-ich-bin-sophie-scholl (accessed 25.11.2024).
8. All media are multimodal and intermedial (Elleström 2021: 4). On digital intermediality in the context of modelling, see chapter 4 of Ciula et al (2023).

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